



Origin Genesis

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ASRock H81 Pro BTC

It's time to start mining for cryptocurrency



Price
₹5,500
(+ Tax)

The world has gone nuts with cryptocurrency and everyone is into mining Bitcoins and other digital currencies like Litecoins, Dogecoins etc., So much computing power is currently in use in this domain that the difficulty of mining these coins has risen considerably (the number of coins mined is directly proportional to the difficulty).

One can mine these coins on all platforms, you can use your phone or tablet, your CPU or your graphics card. However, these platforms are no longer viable. The simple reason is that the difficulty parameter is so high that in order to break even you'd have to mine for hundreds of years. But that's not considering the electricity costs, bring that into the picture and you are never going to earn at all. Don't lose hope because now you have ASIC miners which are basically simple processors that can crunch a high volume of these calculations.

Graphics cards are similar to ASIC in function but the volume of calculations they can manage is considerably lower. Yet new ASICs have come into the picture that have been constructed to communicate via PCIe which means one can still utilise a high computational workload on the motherboard. These cards, however, do not need the full x16 bandwidth that a PCIe port provides. x1 is more than enough since the data being sent is simply a hash and a set of instructions.

ASRock has come out with the H81 Pro BTC for this very purpose of mining coins using your PC.

This way you can start off on a familiar platform and then move onto something more complex when the need arises. The H81 Pro BTC has one PCIe x16 slot so that traditional GPUs can be mounted. In order to utilise the remaining five PCIe x1 slots you'll need to make use of PCIe riser cards which can communicate with traditional GPUs as well but don't expect to get video output from them.

Buildwise the board can't fit six GPUs since it is not only physically impossible but the heat generated by doing so will also be detrimental to all the components. Also there are two extra molex power connectors on the motherboard to supplement the GPUs and these need to be connected to the same power supply as the GPUs. Now that's a difficult prospect since traditional GPUs require a lot of power in terms of wattage. You'll need to daisy chain a couple of PSUs to obtain enough power to run all the GPUs at full load. Even the ASIC PCIe bitcoin mining cards require a lot of power, the 600 GH/s capable card requires 350W which is quite a lot. However, with six such cards your mining potential rises to $600 \times 6 = 3600$ GH/s. That translates roughly 0.366 bitcoins generated per day, that's \$207 per day.

The remaining components on the motherboard happen to be standard fare with the 5.1 audio output and gigabit ethernet port. And 16 GBs of RAM is more than necessary for a rig devoted to purely mining. Which is why a H81 chipset is all that you need, anything higher is completely useless. Our testing methodology pits this board against other high-end boards and thus, this board scores lower. But you need to keep in mind that this board is for a specialised purpose and thus is devoid of features that are generally available on other boards. USB 3.0 ports are not present on this board because the bandwidth that would usually have been allotted for USB 3.0 has been repurposed to make more PCIe slots available. Other than that, this board even has a parallel port and a COM port which means you can use legacy hardware with it.

One issue that we happen to have is that with this particular board they haven't included any riser cards which are absolutely essential in order to make use of this board in the first place. Other than that, the ASRock H81 Pro BTC is worth what you pay for and great to dabble in bitcoins.

Mithun Mobandas

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Build75

Specifications

Chipset: H81; **Memory support:** 2x1600MHz upto 16GB; **LAN:** Realtek RTL8111GR Gigabit Ethernet; **Audio:** ALC662 5.1; **SATA:** 2x SATA III; **Expansion:** PCIe x16, 5x PCIe x1; **Dimensions (LxWxD):** 305 mm x 178 mm; **Warranty:** 3 years

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